

Some people think that philosophy is of no relevance to everyday concerns.

I hope that our class has disabused you of this notion. However, in this last class, I would like to turn the tools of philosophical analysis on two questions of great current concern.

Was the College Football Playoff
committee's decision to exclude
Notre Dame competent, or
incompetent?

Was the College Football Playoff committee's decision to exclude Notre Dame honest, or corrupt?

Logically that there are four exclusive and exhaustive possibilities.

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.

Here is an argument against the first possibility.

1. If the committee's decision was competent and honest, then the committee did not rely on absurd principles in making its decision.
2. The committee relied on absurd principles in making its decision.

C. The committee's decision was not competent and honest. (1,2)

The argument is valid, and the first premise is obvious. It remains therefore to demonstrate the second premise.

The committee's task is to rank the country's football teams from best to worst, based on their performance. This is a general kind of task. One might also seek to similarly rank the best universities, or best philosophy departments, or best cars, or whatever.

One may rely on various principles in constructing rankings of this kind, and the appropriate principles will of course depend on the ranking. Nonetheless we can isolate one general kind of principle which one might use, which I will call a **magic touching rule**.

A magic touching rule is a rule which says that when two of the ranked items are 'touching' — i.e., adjacent in the rankings — then we look to a special extra condition — this is the magic part — to see whether the two touching items in the ranking should have their spots flipped.

Magic touching rule

If two teams in the ranking are touching and played head to head and the lower ranked team defeated the higher ranked team then the teams' rankings are flipped.

The committee employs a rule of this kind.

It is easy to argue that magic touching rules are, in general, dumb. Either the extra condition (in this case the head to head result) is relevant to the ranking or it is not. If it is, it should be incorporated into the original ranking, in which case the flip is 'double counting' the relevance of the extra condition. If it is not relevant, it should also not be relevant in the special case of touching.

Further absurdities follow from the fact that the extra condition (winning a head to head matchup) is not a transitive relation.

Suppose that we have the following results: Team A beat Team B, Team B beat Team C, and Team C beat Team A.

Suppose now that we arrive at the following initial rankings:

Here is a second argument against the view that the decision
was competent and honest.

1. If the committee's decision was competent and honest, then the committee did not inconsistently apply its own principles.
2. The committee inconsistently applied its own principles.

C. The committee's decision was not competent and honest. (1,2)

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.

Now we face our most difficult question. Was the committee incompetent and honest or incompetent and corrupt? In our current state of evidence, we do not have an argument which decisively settles this question.

However, we have already discussed a mechanism for arriving at probabilistic beliefs in such cases: Bayes' theorem.

Recall that in order to determine the probability of some hypotheses given the evidence, we need two pieces of information: the prior probabilities of the theories, and the probability of the evidence given the theories.

Being fair-minded, let's say that the prior probabilities that the committee was incompetent and corruptly biased toward conferences and incompetent and not so corruptly biased are each 0.5.

$$P(\text{CORRUPT}) = 0.5$$

$$P(\text{HONEST}) = 0.5$$

Our evidence (e) will be the committee's decisions from the 4th playoff
rankings onwards.

As we will see, there is only a narrow path for these decisions which would have allowed Notre Dame to be excluded. Despite the narrowness of the path and the committee's general incompetence, the probability of a series of Notre Dame-excluding decisions conditional on CORRUPT is high. Choice of numbers are somewhat arbitrary, but the following appears to be a conservative choice:

$$P(e \mid \text{CORRUPT}) = 0.8$$

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The argument is valid, and the first premise is obvious. It remains therefore to demonstrate the second premise.

One may rely on various principles in constructing rankings of this kind, and the appropriate principles will of course depend on the ranking. Nonetheless we can isolate one general kind of principle which one might use, which I will call a **magic touching rule**.



current concern.

hope that our class has disabled you of this notion. However, in this last class, I

would like to turn the topic of philosophical analysis into questions of great

Was the College Football Playoff
committee's decision to exclude
Notre Dame competent, or
incompetent?

Was the College Football Playoff
committee's decision to exclude
Notre Dame honest, or corrupt?

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.



1. If the committee's decision was competent and honest, then the committee did not rely on absurd principles in making its decision.
2. The committee relied on absurd principles in making its decision.

C. The committee's decision was not competent and honest. (1,2)

remains therefore to demonstrate the second premise.

The argument is valid, and the first premise is obvious. It

the best universities, or best philosophy departments, or best

cars, or whatever.

general kind of task. One might also seek to similarly rank

from best to worst, based on their performance. This is a

The committee's task is to rank the country's football teams

general kind of principle which one might use, which will

of this kind, and the appropriate principles will of course

One may rely on various principles in constructing rankings

call it magic touch thing rule.

dependent on the ranking. Nonetheless we can isolate one

is the magic part — whether the two touching items

rankings — then we look to a special extra condition — this

in the rankings should have their spots flipped.

the ranked items are 'touching' i.e., adjacent in the

A magical thinking rule is a rule which says that when two of

Magic touching rule

If two teams in the ranking are touching and played head to head and the lower ranked team defeated the higher ranked team then the teams' rankings are flipped.

as the flip is 'doubling' the relevance of the extra

condition. If it is not relevant, it should also not be relevant

head result) is relevant to the ranking or it is not. If it is, it

in the special case of touching.

It is easy to argue that magic touching rules, in general,

should be incorporated into the original ranking, in which

dumb. Either the extra condition (in this case the head to

condition (winning a head to head matchup) is not a

Furtherabunditiesfollowthefactthatthe

transitive relation.

Team B, Team Beat Team C, and Team Beat Team A.

Support that we have the following results: Team A beat

Here is a second argument against the view that the decision

was competent and honest.

1. If the committee's decision was competent and honest, then the committee did not inconsistently apply its own principles.
2. The committee inconsistently applied its own principles.

C. The committee's decision was not competent and honest. (1,2)

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.

decisively settles this question.

current state of evidence, we do not have an argument which

incompetent and honest incompetent and corrupt? In our

Now we face our most difficult question. Was the committee

probabilistic beliefs: Bayes' theorem.

However, we have already discussed mechanisms for arriving at

Recall that in order to determine the probability of some

the prior probabilities of the theories, and the probability of the

evidence given the theories.

hypotheses given the evidence, we need two pieces of information:

$$P(\text{CORRUPT}) = 0.5$$

$$P(\text{HONEST}) = 0.5$$

Our evidence (e) will be the committee's decisions from the 4th playoff

ranking onwards.

As we will see, there is only a narrow path for these decisions which

the probability of a series of Notre Dame excluding decisions

arbitrary, but the following appears to be a consistent choice:

would have allowed Notre Dame to be excluded. Despite the

conditional on CO₂RRdP is high. Chosen numbers are what

nameness of the path and the committee's general incompetence,

$$P(e \mid \text{CORRUPT}) = 0.8$$

$$P(\text{CORRUPT}) = 0.5$$

$$P(\text{HONEST}) = 0.5$$

$$P(e \mid \text{CORRUPT}) = 0.8$$